

Ciara Looney

Junior Game Designer

US and EU citizen. No sponsorship required. Open to relocation.

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Software developer moving into game design. Game design is where my creativity and technical background meet. I've designed and shipped playable games across Unity and the Nintendo DS, each documented with design decisions. I care about how games bring joy to players and what keeps people playing.

GAME DESIGN PROJECTS

Ship It! – Arcade Unity Game · ciaralooney.netlify.app/ship-it

- Designed and built a 60 second conveyor-belt sorting game in Unity using C#. The items have a ramping spawn rate that teaches the player the sorting mechanic early and tests their skills under pressure later in the game.
- I took time to balance scoring, so sorting an item incorrectly costs more than a missed item. This ensures players don't spam to clear the belt.
- I rebalanced item spawn rates after playtests showed later in the game it was impossible to keep up with the items.

Smooth Snake for the Nintendo DS · ciaralooney.netlify.app/smooth-snake

- A stylus-controlled snake game for the Nintendo DS made using C with no engine.
- Built and completed my first DS game, gaining hands-on experience in platform-specific design. I had to conduct careful testing to ensure the touchscreen controls worked accurately as accuracy is essential later in the game

Hop Hop Hop! – Survival Unity Game · ciaralooney.netlify.app/hophophop

- Designed and built a survival game in Unity using C# where every lilypad starts sinking the moment you land on it. Sink time shrinks the longer you survive, so the difficulty ramps inside the core mechanic.
- Originally the player was scored based on how many lilypads they hopped on, but playtesting showed nothing was pushing the player forward. The game was revamped with the lilypads breaking mechanic and survival time.

Level Design for an upcoming 2D platformer · ciaralooney.netlify.app/level-design

- Greyboxed 5 platformer levels in Unity. Each level teaches the player a new mechanic. My documentation shows level drafts and changes made after playtester feedback.
- I moved a level from level 5 to level 2 when playtests showed it was too easy for a final level. Adjusted walls and platforms when playtesters consistently missed the timing.

Interactive Audio Games for the Yoto Player · ciaralooney.netlify.app/yoto

- Two voice-driven games (trivia and choose your own adventure) for a kids audio player. The physical card triggers a live server and buttons on the player are used to make choices.
- Designed branching narrative and feedback to give players meaningful choices through an audio-only interface.

SOFTWARE PROJECTS

Agile Group Project - Booking website and matching app (team of 3)

- Built an interactive booking website and matching app built with JavaScript, CSS and Node.js using MongoDB for database management.
- Took on group leader role, assigned tasks via Trello, organised meetings, liaised updates with lecturer.

AI Investment Platform - Website and matching app (team of 4)

- Website (Node.js/MongoDB) with AI-driven investment advice and a companion app (Kotlin and Firebase).
- I owned full authentication (login, signup, password reset) for the website and the app. I also owned the Google Pay integration on the app.

GAME WORK EXPERIENCE

Sky Castle Studios

Nov. 2021

Playtester

- Conducted structured playtesting on an unreleased tabletop game prototype for Sky Castle Studios (developers of Hero Forge)
- Provided feedback on mechanics and balance from a player's perspective during prototype iteration.

OTHER WORK EXPERIENCE

Smarttech 24/7

Nov. 2025 - Current

Automation Implementation Graduate

- Design and build automated security workflows using Python and Swimlane SOAR, from analyst use case through deployment.
- I collaborate with cybersecurity analysts to turn their use cases into automation playbooks and a UI they use daily.

Dell Technologies

Feb. - Aug. 2025

Software Development Intern

- I worked in an agile team with daily standups and sprint reviews. I also took on a mentoring role for a summer intern.
- Built a Python/Flask tool using Llama AI to generate Jira tickets from user input, automating creation via the Jira API.
- I helped organise the Hackathon and automated participant certificate generation and emailing using Python.

Dell Technologies

June - Aug. 2024

Tech Support

- I would help employees set up their new laptop and answer any queries.
- I ensured zero downtime for 40+ manufacturing PCs by planning replacements ahead of schedule.

University College Cork

June - Aug. 2020

Software Developer Intern

- I built a scraping program with Golang that would scan for dead links on a website.
- I communicated with a mentor through Slack, I would update them on progress and adapt the project to their ideas.

EDUCATION

Munster Technological University

2022-2025

BSc in Software Development

- **Final Result:** Graduated with Distinction
- **Sample Results:** Modular Prog: 90%; Prog. Fundamentals: 91%; Systems Scripting 86%.

St. John's College

2021-2022

Game Design and Development

Rochester Institute of Technology (Online)

2020

Video Game Design and Balance

St. Aloysius, Cork

2015-2021

Leaving Certificate

SKILLS & INTERESTS

- **Design:** Level design & greyboxing; prototyping; playtesting & iteration; game balancing; game design documents
- **Technical:** Unity (2D and 3D); C#; C; Python; Kotlin; Java; JavaScript; Node.js; Git; HTML/CSS
- **Interests:** Nintendo DS homebrew development; programming my Ohbot robot; Travelling; favourite games include Minecraft, Stardew Valley, and almost everything Nintendo